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Prof. Rachel Hutcheson

Masterpieces of Western Art - Exhibition Proposal

07 /03/ 2025

Title: *The Art of the Self: Gazes Across Time*

Proposed Exhibition Space: The Museum of Modern Art (MoMA), New York City

Standing in front of a painting that is visually captivating is a powerful experience; it allows viewers to appreciate the technical mastery and emotional resonance of the artist. Yet there is something uniquely profound when artists turn the gaze inward and depict themselves. A self-portrait requires more than technical skill; it demands vulnerability, reflection, and the courage to shape one's image. Unlike traditional portraits of kings, saints, or imagined figures, self-portraits offer a dual lens, revealing both the physical appearance and inner world of the artist. They provide intimate insight into how individuals perceive themselves and how they wish to be perceived by others.

This exhibition, *The Art of the Self: Gazes Across Time*, explores the evolution of self-portraiture as a site of expression, transformation, and power. Featuring four compelling works by Sofonisba Anguissola, Rembrandt van Rijn, Pablo Picasso, and Frida Kahlo, artists spanning from the 16th to the 20th century, it traces how the genre of self-portraiture has allowed artists to challenge conventions, assert their agency, and reimagine themselves through art. At its core, the exhibition argues that self-portraiture is not merely an artistic genre but a powerful act of self-definition that

enables artists to explore, assert, and transform their identities in response to personal, cultural, and societal forces.

Held at the Museum of Modern Art (MoMA) in New York City, a space renowned for showcasing innovative and thought-provoking exhibitions, this show invites audiences to engage deeply with the enduring art of self-representation. The gallery's white walls evoke clarity, honesty, and introspection, serving as a neutral yet symbolic canvas that amplifies the individuality and emotional resonance of each work.

In an era dominated by selfies and curated digital personas, these historical self-portraits feel strikingly contemporary, reminding us that representing oneself is never a simple act. Whether through Anguissola's quiet assertion, Rembrandt's introspective ambiguity, Picasso's stylized detachment, or Kahlo's radical vulnerability, each artist frames identity as both a mirror and a mask. Together, their works invite us to reflect on the shifting boundaries between how we see ourselves, how we are seen, and what it means to be truly known.

1. Sofonisba Anguissola, *Self-Portrait at the Easel* (ca. 1556)

Anguissola's self-portrait opens the exhibition with a quiet but powerful declaration of artistic identity. As one of the few professional women painters of the Renaissance, her work challenges the boundaries imposed by gender in 16th-century Italy. Depicting herself mid-stroke while painting the Virgin and Child, Anguissola aligns herself with divine creation and intellectual labor. Her calm gaze meets the viewer directly, asserting control over both her craft and her self-image.

The inclusion of religious subject matter, traditionally associated with male painters, highlights her skill while subtly reframing female roles. She wears a modest black dress, neither flamboyant nor decorative, underscoring her professionalism. The composition's structure, with the viewer's eye drawn from the sacred image to Anguissola herself, reinforces her authorship. In this way, she not only claims space as a woman in the male-dominated world of Renaissance art but also uses self-representation to redefine creative agency. Her portrait sets the stage for the exhibition's central theme: how artists use self-portraiture to navigate identity within cultural constraints.

2. Rembrandt van Rijn, *Self-Portrait* (c. 1628)

If Anguissola's self-portrait asserts calm control, Rembrandt's early depiction introduces the psychological complexity of identity in flux. Painted when he was only 22, Rembrandt's dimly lit, expressive face emerges from a dark background, his features partially obscured by shadow. The ambiguity of his expression, neither fully open nor fully hidden, mirrors a young artist grappling with self-definition.

There is a stark contrast between the polish of Anguissola's composition and Rembrandt's raw, unfinished quality. He presents himself not as a finished product but as a subject in progress, unsure yet searching. This portrait is less about how he wants to be remembered and more about capturing a fleeting, uncertain moment of becoming. Through visible brushstrokes and soft transitions of light, Rembrandt invites the viewer into an intimate, unguarded confrontation with the self. His work expands the thesis by showing how self-portraiture can serve not just as self-assertion, but also as introspective inquiry, revealing identity in formation rather than resolution.

3. Pablo Picasso, *Self-Portrait* (1906)

Where Rembrandt's self-examination is emotional and intimate, Picasso's self-portrait is cold, constructed, and symbolic. Picasso's image distorts the face almost into abstraction: one eye is a black void, the expression blank, the lines harsh and angular. There is no attempt at realism or psychological depth. Instead, Picasso rejects traditional portraiture entirely, recasting identity as a visual experiment.

His deliberate stylization, echoing influences from Iberian and African art, distances the viewer emotionally but asserts another kind of truth: identity as mutable, performative, and shaped by aesthetic and cultural forces. Unlike Anguissola's emphasis on skill or Rembrandt's vulnerability, Picasso's image is a mask, one that conceals as much as it reveals. He resists being known, choosing instead to reconstruct himself as an idea. In doing so, his work confronts the limits of authenticity and challenges the viewer to question whether any self-portrait can ever be truly "real." His contribution to the exhibition underscores self-portraiture as a radical act of reinvention.

4. Frida Kahlo, *Self-Portrait with Cropped Hair* (1940)

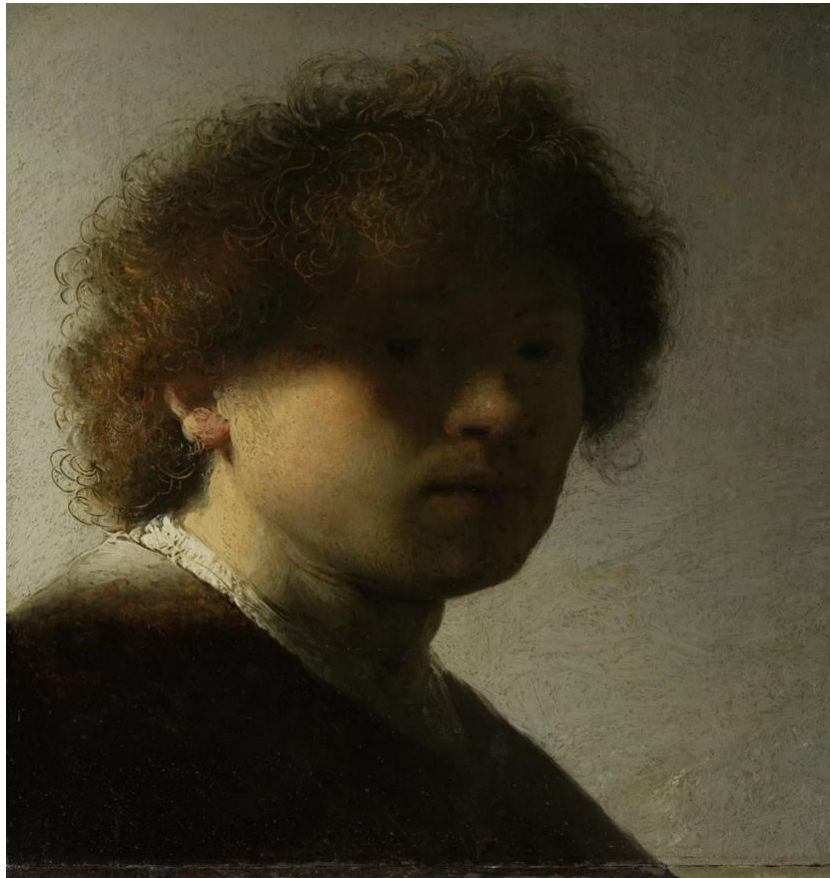
Kahlo's portrait brings the exhibition to a crescendo of personal and political expression. Painted shortly after her divorce from Diego Rivera, this image shows her in an oversized men's suit, clutching scissors in one hand and her freshly cut hair in the other. Scattered strands surround her feet like fallen pieces of identity. Yet, despite the masculine attire, she retains elements of femininity, earrings, lipstick, and heels, suggesting that gender is not fixed but fluid.

This act of cutting her hair becomes a powerful symbol of rupture and renewal. The lyric above her reads: "Look, if I loved you, it was because of your hair. Now that you're bald, I don't love you anymore." In response, Kahlo seizes control of her image. She is not diminished by heartbreak

but remade through it. The sparse room amplifies the starkness of the moment, reinforcing her isolation but also her autonomy. Unlike Picasso's strategic detachment, Kahlo's self-portrait is charged with emotional defiance. She transforms personal pain into a manifesto of self-possession. Kahlo's portrait brings the exhibition full circle, echoing Anguissola's self-assertion, Rembrandt's vulnerability, and Picasso's reinvention, while pushing the boundaries of self-portraiture into territory that is boldly political and deeply intimate. Her work affirms the exhibition's thesis that self-portraiture is a tool of transformation, where power can be lost, reclaimed, and redefined.

Across centuries and styles, these four self-portraits reveal that self-representation is never static; it is a continual process of becoming. From Anguissola's quiet assertion of artistic intellect to Rembrandt's vulnerable introspection, Picasso's radical reinvention, and Kahlo's fierce reclamation of identity, each work reflects the artist's struggle to define themselves in the face of societal expectations, personal doubt, and evolving self-awareness. What unites them is not just their artistic skill, but their courage to turn inward, to make themselves visible on their own terms. In a time when self-image is endlessly curated and consumed, these portraits remind us that the act of seeing and being seen is inherently complex, personal, and political. *The Art of the Self: Gazes Across Time* is not just an exhibition of likenesses; it is a meditation on transformation, resistance, and the enduring power of the human gaze.





Materials
Oil on panel

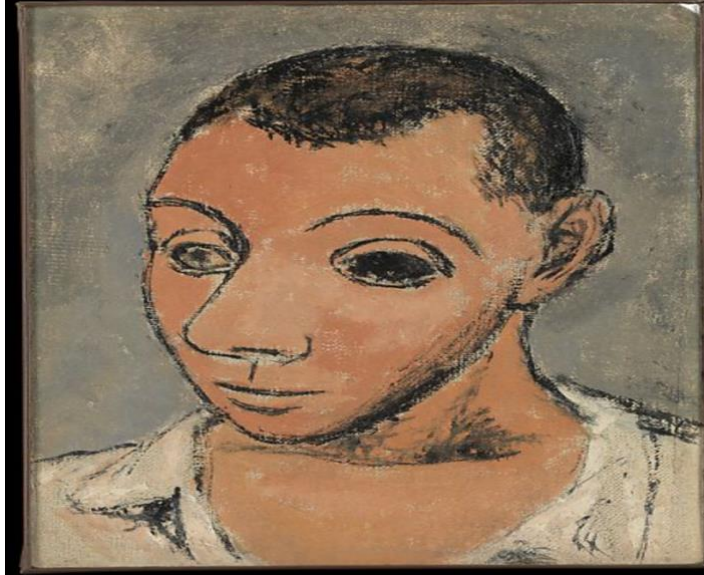
Size
8 9/10 × 7 2/5 in | 22.6 × 18.7 cm

Medium
Painting

Rijksmuseum
Amsterdam

Image rights
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²Rembrandt van Rijn. *Self-portrait* (1628). Rijksmuseum, Amsterdam. <https://www.artsy.net/artwork/rembrandt-van-rijn-self-portrait-1660>



Title: Self-Portrait

Artist: Pablo Picasso (Spanish, Malaga 1881–1973 Mougins, France)

Date: 1906

Medium: Oil on canvas mounted on honeycomb panel

Dimensions: 10 1/2 x 7 3/4 in. (26.7 x 19.7 cm)

Classification: Paintings

Credit Line: Jacques and Natasha Gelman Collection, 1998

Object Number: 1999.363.59

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³Pablo Picasso. *Self Portrait* (1906). The Metropolitan Museum of Art, New York.
<https://www.metmuseum.org/art/collection/search/490014>



Medium

Oil on canvas

Dimensions

5 3/4 x 11" (40 x 27.9 cm)

Credit

Gift of Edgar Kaufmann, Jr.

Object number

1943

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Department

Painting and Sculpture

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Frida Kahlo. *Self-Portrait with Cropped Hair* (1940). The Museum of Modern Art, New York.
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